Chapter 1

The Teop people and their language

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The Teop people live in the Autonomous Region of Bougainville Island of Papua New Guinea, in the Local Level Government area Tinputz of the North Bougainville District. On the map in Figure 1 this area includes the Teop Harbour which lies south of the village Tinputz.



Figure 1: Vicinity of Bougainville Island (from https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Un-bougainville.png)

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Teop is an Oceanic Austronesian language that belongs to the Nehan-North Bougainville network of the North-West Solomonic Group of the Meso-Melanesian North-West Solomonic Group (Ross 1988: 217).[1] Figure 2 shows the languages spoken in the Autonomous Region of Bougainville. The current number of speakers of the Teop language is unknown. According to Grimes (2000), quoted by Tryon (2015: 37) the number of speakers was 5,000 in 1991. During our documentation project (1994–2014) Teop people estimated that the number of Teop speakers was about 6,000.

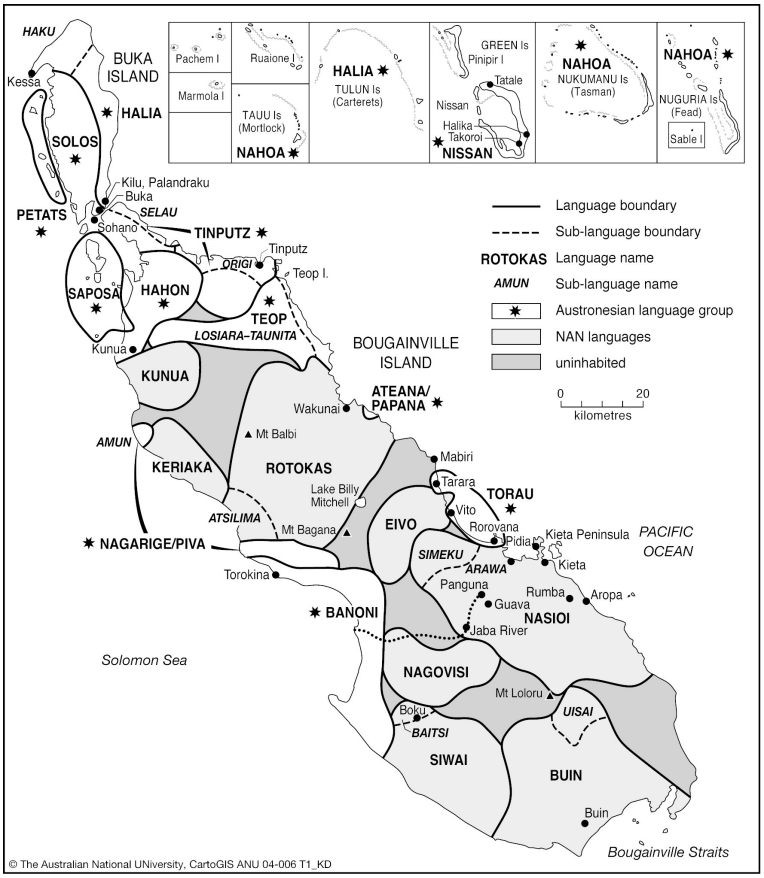


Figure 2: The languages of the Autonomous Region of Bougainville, Papua New Guinea (from ANU CartoGIS)

[1]Extensive resources in and about the Teop language are archived in the Open Language Archives Community (OLAC), see http://language-archives.org/ and OLAC resources in and about the Teop language: http://www.language-archives.org/language/tio.

Besides the official languages English and Tok Pisin, the Autonomous Region of Bougainville counts 17 Austronesian and eight Papuan languages.[2] According to the Bougainville Human Development Report more than 80% of the population of North Bougainville were literate (Chalmers 2009). The report does not distinguish between literacy in English, Tok Pisin or vernacular languages in its statistics.

[2]See Tryon (2015: 37, 40) and Smith-Dennis (2020: 2–4), and the references given there.